Own the Preference Before the Pipeline

Demand creation & lead nurture in specification-driven B2B — a point of view

In specification-driven B2B, the sale is shaped long before the tender is written. The funnel therefore does not start at the lead — it starts at inspiration. Three phases, one model: own consideration, define WHO × WHAT × HOW for new customers, and treat existing customers as a source of insight — not only of revenue.

Lars Glade · August 2026

One funnel, three phases — and a loop

Preference is built at the top, converted in the middle, and regenerated at the bottom.

PHASE 1 · CONSIDERATION — MUST OWN

Inspiration & preference-building with specifiers, architects and decision-shapers — before commercial intent exists

PHASE 2 · NEW CUSTOMERS — WHO × WHAT × HOW

Segmentation and account selection, proposition and content per role, channel and engagement model — pipeline quality over volume

PHASE 3 · EXISTING CUSTOMERS & CONTACTS

Repurchase, upsell and reference selling — and inspiration, motivation and feedback: customers as your truest source of insight

Insight loop: feedback feeds Phase 1 content

Measured incrementally at every phase — share of preference, pipeline quality, conversion vs. control. An effect that cannot be measured does not count.

Phase 1 · Consideration — must own

The preference is built before the tender is written. Content is not campaigning — it is preference formation.

Who shapes the decision

Architects, specifiers, advisors, contractors — map the influence chain per segment and market. The buyer signs; the specifier decides.

Inspire, don't sell

High-funnel content that helps the specifier succeed at their job: knowledge, standards, cases, tools. Commercial intent comes later — credibility comes first.

Must-own moments

Identify the recurring situations where preference is formed — early design, regulation shifts, material choice — and own them with systematic presence.

Measure preference

Share of specification, content engagement by role, brand preference in the influence chain — leading indicators, tracked before pipeline exists.

Phase 2 · New customers — WHO × WHAT × HOW

From preference to pipeline: quality is a choice made at selection, not a hope applied at conversion.

WHO

Account selection and segmentation by potential and win probability — deciding who not to pursue is half the discipline. Prospecting focused where preference already exists.

WHAT

Proposition and content per role in the buying chain — the specifier, the buyer, the contractor hear different arguments. Conversion kits and playbooks built with sales, not for them.

HOW

Channel and engagement model per segment: when marketing automation nurtures, when sales engages, and what triggers the handover. Standardised, governed, adopted.

Pipeline quality, proven: every lead flow measured incrementally against control. The question is never “did we generate leads?” but “did these leads convert better than the ones we chose not to pursue?”

Phase 3 · Existing customers & contacts

The base is not only revenue — it is your truest source of insight, and the engine that refills Phase 1.

Commercial value

Repurchase, upsell and cross-sell governed by CLV and lead economics — plus reference selling: satisfied specifiers and contractors as the strongest demand generators you have.

Inspire & motivate

Keep engaging beyond the transaction: knowledge, community, early access to what is coming. A contact who feels invested recommends, specifies and returns.

Feedback as strategy

Systematic listening — not satisfaction surveys, but structured insight into where their world is heading. Their future needs are your future portfolio and content.

The loop closes: insight from the base shapes the content that wins consideration — so the funnel is not a pipe but a flywheel. Governance, shared KPIs and incremental measurement keep it honest. That is the machinery I build.

From model to machine — how I would run it

A framework nobody uses is cost, not capability. Enablement, adoption and execution are one discipline.

The enablement toolkit

Conversion kits, playbooks and sales collateral per segment and role — built with the frontline. CRM flows, dashboards and pipeline reporting designed for action: performance variation between segments and channels as the engine of improvement.

The adoption mechanics

Consensus without formal authority is my daily craft: shared KPIs, a governance forum with mandate, and adoption tracked as a metric — tools refined on frontline feedback. Commercial standards for quality engagement set jointly across Marketing and Sales.

The execution rhythm

Classical project discipline — deliverables, owners, timelines, risk log — and regular senior-stakeholder reporting on progress, pipeline quality trends and enablement ROI. First 90 days: baseline, two must-win use cases, prove effect vs. control. Then scale market by market, shaped with the markets themselves.

Proven pattern: Lead Forum governance and incentive redesign at Topdanmark/If → €5–8M incremental sales vs. control. CRM engine at YouSee → +19,000 incremental sales, ~€10M annually. Same machinery, new market.